

HEALTH AND FITNESS



IF A MACHINE is treated with care and given proper maintenance, it is more likely to function efficiently.

Similarly, the human body is most likely to function to the best of its ability if it is kept fit and healthy. Health may be defined as the state of being well in body and mind. Fitness is an indication of how efficiently the body's muscles, heart, and lungs are working. If people are fit, they can deal with the requirements put upon their bodies by everyday activities, such as walking and lifting, but also with sudden demands, such as sprinting for a bus. Mental health – the mind's fitness – is also important for well-being.



What is health?

When someone is in good health it means their body is working to its full potential and is not impeded by physical or mental diseases. People's health may suffer as they become older, if they eat a poor diet, if they are poor, if they are exposed to pollution, or work in a harmful environment.

Outdoor play contributes to the healthy development of children.

Maintaining health

Many people in developed countries are overweight, take little exercise, and eat too much fatty food. This makes them unfit, and often unhealthy. Following a balanced diet with plenty of fresh fruit and vegetables and not too much fat, combined with regular exercise, aid better health.

Diet

A healthy diet consists of the right amounts of protein, carbohydrate, fat, vitamins, minerals, and fibre. The energy it provides should keep the body at its ideal weight.



Fruit and vegetables are full of vitamins.



Fish provides energy, iron, and protein.



Dairy products provide protein and fat.



Meat is full of protein and vitamins.



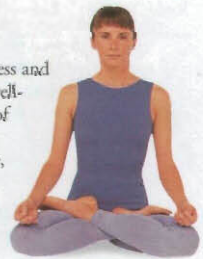
Nuts and fungi contain protein and minerals.



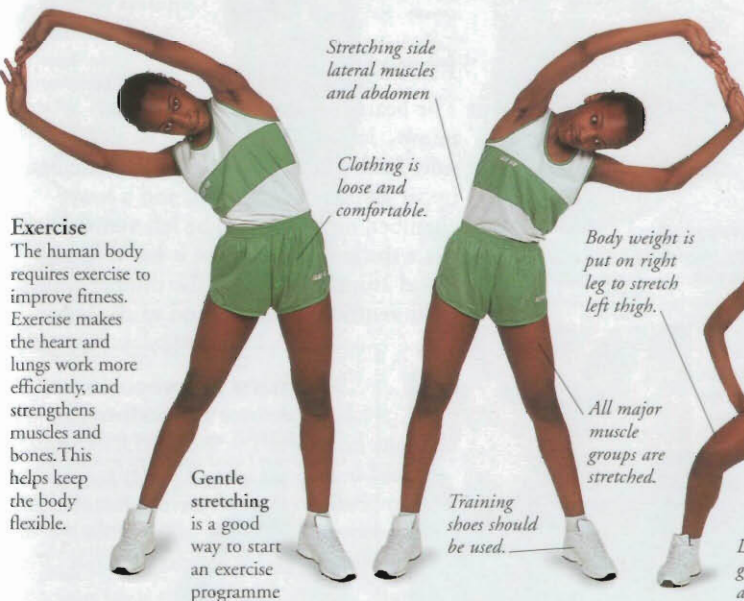
Pulses, rice, and pasta provide carbohydrates.

Relaxation

Regular relaxation reduces stress and tension, increases a sense of well-being, and decreases the risk of disease. There are many ways to relax, including massage, yoga, and meditation.



Yoga lotus position



Stretching side lateral muscles and abdomen

Clothing is loose and comfortable.

Body weight is put on right leg to stretch left thigh.

All major muscle groups are stretched.

Training shoes should be used.

Legs are stretched gently to prevent any strain.

Exercise

The human body requires exercise to improve fitness. Exercise makes the heart and lungs work more efficiently, and strengthens muscles and bones. This helps keep the body flexible.

Gentle stretching is a good way to start an exercise programme

Mental health

Mental health is the fitness of the mind. Problems may be caused by heredity or emotional problems caused by relationships or lifestyle. Keeping fit, discussing problems, and seeking professional help can all improve a person's mental health. Some people are affected by mental illnesses that have been caused by brain disorders.



Doctors who look after mental health are called psychiatrists.

Public health

Public health is concerned with the effect environment has upon a population's health, and how the health of the community can be improved. Workers in this field are interested in, for example, good housing, effective sanitation, reducing air pollution, and the immunization of children and adults against infectious diseases.



Sanitation

Sanitation is the provision of clean drinking water, enclosed sewers, and drains. It stops food and water being contaminated by potentially fatal pathogens (germs) from human waste and helps stop the spread of disease.

Poor sanitation in slums in 19th-century England



Syringe

Immunization

Immunization protects people from disease. It involves injecting them with small amounts of pathogens of a certain disease. This stimulates the body to produce antibodies that fight the disease, producing protection.

Check-ups

A doctor carries out a check-up, or physical examination, to make sure that a person is healthy, and to look out for anything that may be wrong. During a check-up, the doctor will ask the patient how he or she feels, look at and feel the patient's body, use a stethoscope to listen to breathing and the heart, and measure blood pressure.

Doctor examines girl's throat



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